

if any. If you wanted full credit, you had to show your work. Sometimes it was frustrating. If I did the work in my head, why did I have to write it all out? If showing my work was essential to getting to the answer, what was the point of the end result? It wasn't until we started reading all these personal finance books and articles that we realized how essential showing your work is. Because we'll admit, when presented with the details of today's economy—student loan debt, underpaid workers, high inflation, and a \$700 per month cost of living increase in the last two years¹—the answer you might be tempted to jump to is “Yeah, forget thriving, surviving will do.”

We've spent the last ten years reading and rereading dozens of books on money and psychology. We've interviewed hundreds of personal finance experts on our podcast, *Frugal Friends*, and scoured thousands of articles and studies on everything from budgeting to behavioral economics. We've seen a lot of answers to a lot of questions about spending, saving, and managing money. The common flaw we see in this space is that very few people are showing their work. Figuring out “How do I enjoy life, not feel guilty every time I spend money and not totally screw myself over?” is a simple problem that's deceptively complex to solve. And without context, most people stick to shallow answers that make you feel like you're doing something but are never enough to solve the root problem. Anyone can tell you to stop eating out and take your credit card information out of your computer, but who's really doing that? And if they are, how are they doing it? And is that even the right way? We aim to never give a solution without showing our work. Because there's no singular right solution for managing money or spending it, even if everyone is telling you their way is the right way.

It took us some time to figure out the words to use in response to Amber's email about “making frugal fun.” But here's what we said: “Frugality isn't just about shopping less but realizing that shopping isn't what's actually ‘fun’ or making you happy. It's a temporary dopamine hit that so many other things can provide. The things that make us truly happy cannot be bought. We use frugality to get more of those things. To an extent, the chips are stacked against us and there are very real barriers to affording the things we need and want. Anyone saying anything different is gaslighting. But just because the playing field isn't level doesn't mean we can opt out of the game. Being frugal for frugal's sake is a lifestyle that